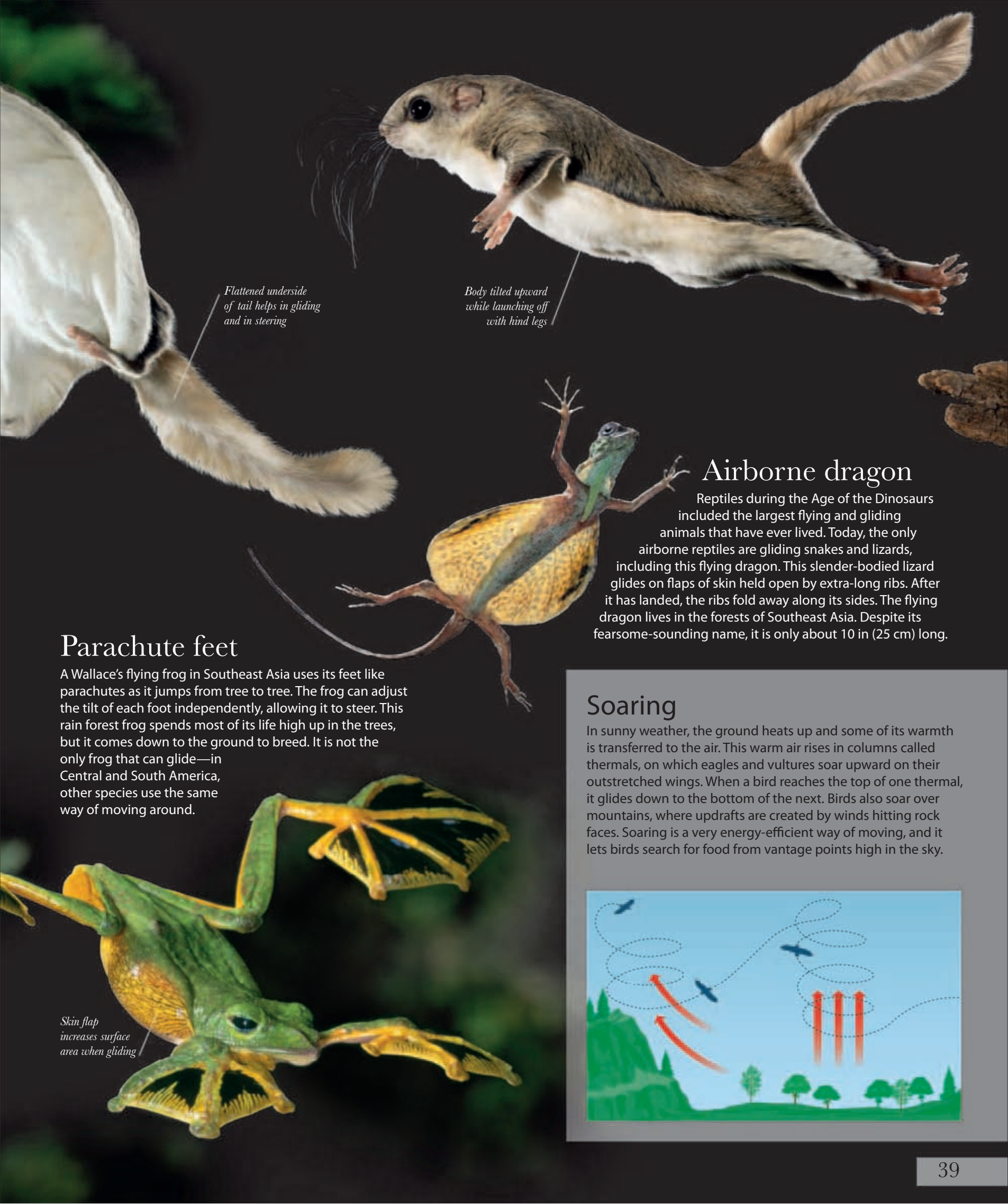




*Flattened underside
of tail helps in gliding
and in steering*

*Body tilted upward
while launching off
with hind legs*

Parachute feet

A Wallace's flying frog in Southeast Asia uses its feet like parachutes as it jumps from tree to tree. The frog can adjust the tilt of each foot independently, allowing it to steer. This rain forest frog spends most of its life high up in the trees, but it comes down to the ground to breed. It is not the only frog that can glide—in Central and South America, other species use the same way of moving around.

*Skin flap
increases surface
area when gliding*

Airborne dragon

Reptiles during the Age of the Dinosaurs included the largest flying and gliding animals that have ever lived. Today, the only airborne reptiles are gliding snakes and lizards, including this flying dragon. This slender-bodied lizard glides on flaps of skin held open by extra-long ribs. After it has landed, the ribs fold away along its sides. The flying dragon lives in the forests of Southeast Asia. Despite its fearsome-sounding name, it is only about 10 in (25 cm) long.

Soaring

In sunny weather, the ground heats up and some of its warmth is transferred to the air. This warm air rises in columns called thermals, on which eagles and vultures soar upward on their outstretched wings. When a bird reaches the top of one thermal, it glides down to the bottom of the next. Birds also soar over mountains, where updrafts are created by winds hitting rock faces. Soaring is a very energy-efficient way of moving, and it lets birds search for food from vantage points high in the sky.

